



YEAR 11 GUIDANCE · FOUNDATION & HIGHER TIERS

The Year 11 GCSE Maths Parent Guide

A practical guide to how GCSE Maths works, what to expect,
and how to support your child through Year 11

1 How GCSE Maths is Assessed

Year 11 is an important school year, but it does not need to be stressful. You do not need to be a maths expert to make a big difference to your child's progress.

This guide explains how GCSE Maths works, what to expect, and how you can help at home in a calm, practical way.

The Exam Format: Three Written Papers

GCSE Maths with the main exam boards in England (AQA, Pearson Edexcel, and OCR) is tested through three written exams at the end of Year 11. There is no coursework.

Topics can appear on any paper. The main difference between the papers is whether students can use a calculator.

Paper	Calculator Allowed?	Share of Final Grade
One written paper	No	One third (33.3%)
Two written papers	Yes	Two thirds (66.7%)

Note: The order of these papers depends on the exam board. The non-calculator exam is not always Paper 1. All three papers have equal marks and count equally towards the final grade.

Using a Scientific Calculator

Calculators are allowed on two of the three papers. Because of this, using a scientific calculator with confidence is an essential skill.

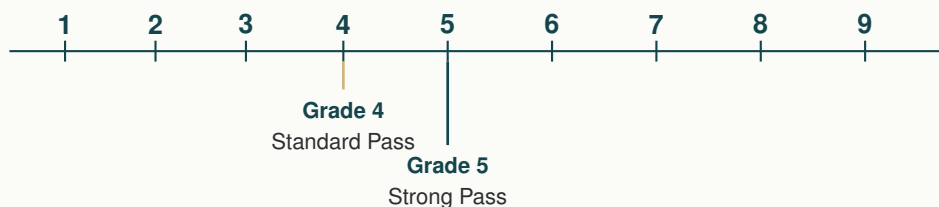
However, a calculator will not choose the method. Students still need to know which calculation to use, type numbers accurately, and understand what the answer means. Regular practice helps students work smoothly and avoid simple errors.

Exam-Approved Equipment

Encourage your child to revise at home with the same scientific calculator they use in class. Knowing where the buttons and keys are helps them feel confident during timed tests.

2 Understanding GCSE Grades & The 9–1 Scale

GCSEs are graded from 9 (highest) down to 1. Knowing what these numbers mean helps you support your child's goals.



What Grades 4 and 5 Mean in Practice

- **Grade 4 (Standard Pass):** A Grade 4 is a real achievement. In England, students who do not achieve at least a Grade 4 in Maths must usually continue studying the subject post-16.
- **Grade 5 (Strong Pass):** A Grade 5 is used as the “strong pass” benchmark in school performance measures. However, a Grade 4 remains a genuine pass for an individual student.
- **Grades 6 to 9:** These higher grades show stronger performance across the more challenging parts of the GCSE syllabus.

College and Sixth Form Entry

Colleges and sixth forms set their own entry rules for each course. If your child wants to study A-Level Maths or courses with lots of maths, check the published entry rules of the college directly.

A Helpful View on Targets

Try not to compare your child's target with other students. The best target is the one that gives your child the right foundation for their chosen next step after Year 11.

3 Foundation vs. Higher Tier in Plain English

One key decision in Year 11 is which tier your child will sit. Understanding the two tiers removes worry and helps you support the school's advice.

Feature	Foundation Tier	Higher Tier
Grades Available	Grades 1 to 5	Grades 4 to 9 (<i>with an allowed Grade 3 for narrow misses</i>)
Question Style	Covers the full Foundation course, with questions ranging from core skills to more demanding Grade 4–5 work.	Includes more demanding content, with greater use of algebra, reasoning, and multi-step problems.
Standard of Gr. 4/5	Exactly the same standard. A Grade 4 or 5 is equal across both tiers.	
GCSE Certificate	Identical certificate. The certificate does not state which tier was sat.	

How Schools Make Tier Decisions

Schools look at classwork, tests, homework, and mock results to choose the right tier for each student.

Official guidance from Ofqual states that students expected to achieve a Grade 4 or Grade 5 should usually sit Foundation Tier. This gives them the best opportunity to show what they know and reach their target grade.

Choosing the Right Tier

Higher Tier is not automatically “better”. The right tier gives your child the best chance to succeed. A Grade 5 achieved on Foundation is a secure pass and carries the exact same value as a Grade 5 achieved on Higher.

FOUNDATION FOCUS

Students aiming for Grades 4 or 5 need solid core skills. Number work, fractions, percentages, ratio, and algebra appear throughout the papers and help pick up marks across many topics.

HIGHER FOCUS

Students on Higher Tier also need solid core skills. They must also become confident with more demanding algebra, linking different topics, and solving longer problems.

4 The Year 11 Maths Roadmap

Year 11 is much easier to handle when you take it stage by stage. What matters most changes as the year goes on.

Phase 1: September — Find the Starting Point

Spot what your child knows well and what they find tricky. Help them settle into a calm, regular home-work routine for the new term.

Phase 2: Autumn Term — Build Strong Foundations

Fill in topic gaps while learning new Year 11 material in class. Focus on steady weekly practice rather than rushing into full exam papers too early.

Phase 3: Mock Exams — See What Needs Work

Treat mock exams as a helpful check-up, not a final verdict. Use the results to spot lost marks, check timing, and see where extra practice is needed.

Phase 4: Spring Term — Focused Practice

Mix topic revision with past exam questions and timed practice. Focus on fixing the specific questions that cost marks in the mocks.

Phase 5: Final Preparation — Stay Calm and Confident

Review topics your child already knows, practise calculator skills, and fix small mistakes. Do not try to relearn the whole syllabus in the final weeks.

A Flexible Timeline

Schools run their mock exams at different times. Use this roadmap as a guide to changing goals across the year, not a fixed calendar.

5 Making Sense of Mock Exams

When mock results come home, it is easy to look only at the grade. However, the best rule to remember is:

A mock result is useful feedback — not a final verdict.

A mock exam simply shows how your child did on one paper, on one day, under timed conditions. Its real value is showing what to practise next.

How to Spot Why Marks Were Lost

Look through the marked paper together to see where marks were dropped:

- **Knowledge Gap:** They did not know or forgot the maths.
What helps: Look back at lesson notes and worked examples before trying more exam questions.
- **Method Error:** They knew the topic, but used the wrong rule or missed a step.
What helps: Compare their working with a model answer to see where it went off track.
- **Arithmetic or Calculator Slip:** The method was right, but a small arithmetic or calculator mistake lost the mark.
What helps: Write down each step clearly so calculations are easy to check.
- **Misreading the Question:** They knew the maths, but missed what the question was asking for.
What helps: Underline key words and numbers, and check what the final answer should show.
- **Running Out of Time / Blank Questions:** Questions were left empty or rushed near the end.
What helps: Check if they got stuck for too long on one hard question early on.

Turning Mocks into an Action Plan

Start with what went well: *“Which questions felt easy?”* Then look at mistakes: *“Did you lose marks on facts you forgot, or simple slips?”* Pick two or three topics to focus on over the next few weeks.

6 Effective Maths Revision at Home

Reading notes or watching videos can help refresh a method. But real maths revision means picking up a pen, paper, and a calculator and working through questions.

A Simple 6-Step Revision Routine

Short, focused sessions work much better than hours of tired reading. A useful revision session might look like this:

- 1. Pick One Topic:** Choose one skill or a small set of related questions.
- 2. Try Questions Alone:** Have a go without looking at notes or answers straight away.
- 3. Check the Steps:** Mark the work and check the working, not just the final answer.
- 4. Fix the Mistake:** Find out why an answer was wrong and write it out correctly.
- 5. Try One More:** Answer a similar question to make sure the fix makes sense.
- 6. Revisit Later:** Come back to the topic later and try a few questions again.

Mixing Topics and Past Papers

Once a topic feels solid, mix questions from different topics. Real exam papers do not have topic titles, so students must practise working out which method to use.

Full past papers are great for practising timing and building stamina. But if your child gets stuck on the same topic each time, stop and practise that topic on its own first.

Show Working and Practise with the Calculator

Encourage your child to write down their working steps. This makes checking easier and may earn method marks where the mark scheme allows them. Make sure they use their school calculator regularly for fractions, powers, and brackets.

7 What to Do When Your Child Gets Stuck

When a student says “*I can’t do any of this*”, it often means one small part has stopped making sense. You do not need to teach the maths yourself. Helping them find the exact sticking point is often all they need to get moving again.

Step 1: Find the Exact Sticking Point

Ask: “*Where did it stop making sense?*” or “*Show me the last line you understood.*” Turning frustration into one clear question makes the problem much easier to fix.

Step 2: Work Out What Kind of Problem It Is

Help them narrow down what is in the way:

- **A Word or Symbol:** Is there a maths word they do not know (like *product* or *integer*)?
- **The First Step:** Do they understand the topic, but do not know how to start?
- **A Forgotten Rule:** Have they seen this before, but forgotten the steps?
- **Wordy Problems:** Do they know the rule, but feel confused by how the question is written?
- **A Small Slip:** Is the method right, but a calculation mistake caused confusion?

Step 3: Fix the Smallest Gap First

Go back one step instead of restarting the whole topic. Look up a keyword, check one worked example in their notebook, or try an easier question first before returning to the main problem.

Give Them Time to Think

It is normal not to know the answer straight away. Give your child some time to think before stepping in. If they stay stuck, help them break the problem down into a smaller step.

8 Five Better Questions to Ask

Talking about revision can be tricky. Big questions like *“Have you revised?”* often lead to shrugs or one-word answers. Asking smaller, more specific questions makes it easier to have a calm and useful chat.

Instead of Asking...	Try Asking...
<i>“Have you done your maths revision?”</i>	“What maths have you been working on today?”
<i>“Why did you get that wrong?”</i>	“Where did it start to go wrong?”
<i>“Do you understand this?”</i>	“Can you show me how you would start it?”
<i>“Why didn’t you finish the paper?”</i>	“Did you run out of time, or were there questions you didn’t know how to start?”
<i>“Are you worried about maths?”</i>	“Which bit of maths is bothering you most at the moment?”

Constructive Questions for Parents’ Evening

When you meet your child’s maths teacher, asking clear questions gives you the most helpful picture:

1. *“What is my child doing well in maths right now?”*
2. *“Which two or three topics would make the biggest difference if they improved?”*
3. *“Are they mainly losing marks through missing knowledge, calculation slips, problem solving, or exam technique?”*
4. *“Which tier are they working towards right now, and could that change?”*
5. *“What is the most helpful thing they could practise at home each week?”*

9 When Extra Support May Help

Every student gets stuck from time to time in Year 11. Extra support can help when the same problems keep coming back, or when a student feels unsure how to move forward on their own.

Signs Extra Support Can Help

- **Repeated Gaps:** The same topics keep causing trouble, even after revision.
- **Stuck Working Alone:** They follow lessons in class, but struggle to start questions on their own at home.
- **Unclear Revision Goals:** They spend time revising, but do not know which topics to focus on.
- **Unsure How to Fix Mocks:** They see where marks were lost, but do not know how to fix those mistakes.
- **Low Confidence:** Worry about getting questions wrong stops them from trying questions independently.

Want a clearer picture of what to work on next?

Hull Maths Tutor offers the **Maths MOT & Action Plan** — a 1-to-1 assessment designed to give you and your child a clear picture of where things stand.

The assessment helps you:

- See which topics are already solid.
- Spot repeated gaps and patterns in lost marks.
- Get a clear, simple plan for what to revise next.

Web: www.hullmathstutor.co.uk

Email: mathstutoringhull@gmail.com

Tel: 07828 579 277

Looking for something your child can try?

Our separate *Year 11 Foundation Maths Back-to-School Booster* is coming soon — a free student resource designed particularly for students working towards securing or improving Grades 3–5 on Foundation Tier.